vacant by Russia—India's main supplier of materiel—as Moscow remains mired in the conflict in Ukraine. With top US and French officials visiting India with an eye on the deal, a decision can be expected in the next few months.

A French delegation led by Sebastien Lecornu, the country's defence minister, began its India visit on November 27, 2022, by inspecting INS *Vikrant* at the Indian Navy's Southern Naval Command in Kochi. Lecornu had come to attend the fourth Indo-French Annual Defence Dialogue with defence minister Rajnath Singh. A few days before that, US Secretary of Navy Carlos Del Toro had also led a delegation to Kochi, boarded INS *Vikrant* and interacted with the ship's crew.

In the second week of January, National Security Advisor Ajit Doval and his French counterpart Emmanuel Bonne discussed security cooperation issues during the latter's visit to New Delhi. It is not known, however, if they discussed a Rafale-M deal. Bonne's visit sets the tone for the upcoming visit of French president Emmanuel Macron to India. According to a report published on January 4 in the French weekly *La Tribune*, a contract for over 26 Rafale-M fighters could be signed during his visit in March 2023. This year also marks the 25th anniversary of the strategic partnership between the two countries.

Similarly, over the past decades, India and the US have drawn closer in a strategic relationship based on shared democratic values. This has deepened over a commitment to ensure a free and open Indo-Pacific region in view of China's aggressive posturing. US commerce secretary Gina Raimondo will visit India in March 2023 with a delegation of global CEOs. In December 2022, the $858 billion defence bill passed by the US Senate sought to strengthen defence ties with India, including supporting efforts to reduce its reliance on Russian equipment.

The Indian Navy has been operating the Russian-origin Mikoyan-Gurevich MiG-29K fighters from the INS *Vikramaditya* ever since the British-made Sea Harriers were phased out. But the MiG-29Ks have a terrible record, with five crashes in the past four years. Hence the navy has ruled them out for the brand new INS *Vikrant*. For years, the navy has been waiting for indigenous fighter jets for its carriers. The naval version of the Light Combat Aircraft (LCA) failed to meet expectations and the programme had to be abandoned. The Aeronautical Development Agency is developing a Twin Engine Deck Based Fighter (TEDBF) for the Indian Navy. But it is still in the research and development stage. Till then, the navy is looking to acquire at least 26 fighter jets as a stopgap arrangement, though aircraft demand for INS *Vikrant* is set at 57.

INS *Vikrant*, which was made to suit Russian aircraft, will need design changes to accommodate F/A-18s or Rafale-Ms

Inducting carrier-based aircraft, be it Rafale-M or the F/A-18, is not a simple matter. As the INS *Vikrant*'s aviation facility is designed to suit Russian fighter jets, the warship will require design changes if the navy goes for French or US fighter jets. Naval experts claim that during trials, compatibility with the carrier's elevator emerged as a major challenge, as the mechanism was designed for the MiG-29Ks. Both the Rafale and the F/A-18 did not fit into it comfortably, despite the folding wings of the Super Hornet.

RAFALE VS SUPER HORNET

Both the Rafale-M and the F/A-18 Super Hornet have specific advantages and disadvantages. As the French pointed out, the Rafale-M, if chosen, will have a shared platform with the IAF's 36 Rafale fighters, and advantages related to training, maintenance and logistics support. But the F/A-18 also gives compatibility with other aircraft which the Indian Navy operates, like the P8I maritime patrol aircraft, Sea Hawk helicopters and the newly received MH60 Romeo helicopters. "All American platforms can communicate with each other and their weapons package is also common. In addition, the navy will get the full support of the US industry," says Admiral Arun Prakash, former chief of the Indian Navy.

Again, Rafale fighter trainers—necessarily two-seaters—cannot land on a carrier and cannot be operationally deployed. Both the two-seater and single-seater versions of the F/A-18 can operate from aircraft carriers.

On the crucial matter of costs, the F/A-18 is likely to be cheaper than the Rafale-M because the US and India conduct military deals under the Foreign Military Sales route—a 'government to government' affair. In France, the government usually does not interfere in defence deals. Moreover, Boeing India president Salil Gupte claims that the selection of the Super Hornet will help boost investments in India's defence industry, for Boeing anticipates economic benefits of $3.6 billion accruing to the Indian economy over 10 years if the aircraft is selected.

The Rafale-M might have impressed the navy, but fewer than 50 units are in service—all in the French navy and its one aircraft carrier in service, the *Charles de Gaulle*. In contrast, F/A-18 Super Hornets operate from all 11 US Navy carriers. Though over 700 F/A-18 Hornets and Super Hornets are in operation, including in the militaries of Australia, Canada, Spain and Kuwait, the deal is critical for Boeing, as their aircraft have recently lost out on export deals to competitors like the Lockheed Martin F-35 (US) and Saab Gripen (Sweden). In 2013, the Super Hornet lost out to the Saab JAS 39 Gripen, when Brazil dropped it from its final list. In 2019, Poland chose the F-35 over the F/A-18 for its air force, as did the UK's Royal Navy, when it opted for the carrier-based 'C' variant of the F-35 for its Queen Elizabeth-class aircraft carriers.

Whichever fighter India chooses, the decision is crucial to its objective of effective projection of power in the Indian Ocean Region in the face of an ever-expanding, ever-aggressive Chinese navy. ■